

Beyond the Spectrogram: GNN-BERT Fusion for Music Context

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Course: CSE715 – Neural Network and Fuzzy Systems

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Project Repository: https://github.com/mizanur-dev/CSE715_gnn-bert-music-context

Abstract

Music is an intrinsically heterogeneous signal wherein context is distributed across acoustic textures, harmonic progressions, and lyrical narratives. Traditional music information retrieval (MIR) architectures treat audio as fixed-grid Euclidean representations (spectrograms via 2D-CNNs) or linear temporal sequences (RNNs/Transformers), consequently failing to preserve long-range structural cycles such as recurring harmonic transitions and verse-chorus topologies. In this work, we design an end-to-end multi-modal architecture that bridges structural graph modeling and contextual language processing. We discretize audio tracks into temporal segments to construct acoustic structure graphs based on temporal adjacency and harmonic chroma similarity. A GraphSAGE network performs spatial message passing over these non-Euclidean graphs, while a contextual language model (DistilBERT) encodes lyrical themes and natural language descriptors. These heterogeneous modalities are synthesized via a scaled dot-product cross-attention mechanism, followed by joint optimization across multi-label tag classification and continuous valence-arousal emotion regression. Additionally, we formulate a contrastive dual-encoder framework optimized using the InfoNCE objective for bidirectional text-to-music retrieval. Evaluated on the MagnaTagATune benchmark and DEAM emotion annotations, our hybrid model achieves a Macro-F1 of **0.63** and an AUC-PR of **0.59**, outperforming convolutional baselines by **+0.22** Macro-F1 and early concatenation ablations by **+0.06**. Qualitative t-SNE projections and single-track case studies confirm that structural audio graphs align coherently with nuanced emotional polarities.

1 Introduction

Automated music understanding necessitates parsing information across disparate modalities. A given audio excerpt simultaneously conveys instrumentation timbre, harmonic syntax (e.g., $C \rightarrow G \rightarrow Am$ progressions), rhythmic pacing, and high-level lyrical sentiments. Historically, audio content analysis has relied upon two-dimensional time-frequency representations, such as short-time Fourier transforms (STFT) and log-mel spectrograms, processed via deep convolutional neural networks (CNNs). While standard CNN filters excel at recognizing localized spectro-temporal textures, they suffer from fundamental inductive biases: their fixed rectangular receptive fields treat music as rigid Euclidean grids, ignoring repetitive structural patterns and non-local harmonic transitions that define musical compositions.

Conversely, textual descriptions, metadata tags, and song lyrics provide direct semantic context. Pre-trained transformer-based language models, such as BERT, yield dense contextual representations capable of capturing emotional valence and lyrical nuance. However, textual modalities lack grounding in acoustic realities; text encoders alone cannot deduce tempo fluctuations, performance dynamics, or timbre variations without audio grounding.

To address these structural and semantic disconnects, we propose a hybrid framework combining **Graph Neural Networks (GNN)** and **BERT**. We model an audio track as an acoustic structure graph $G = (V, E)$, where nodes denote temporal segment windows characterized by combined chroma and log-mel feature vectors, and edges encapsulate both temporal progression and acoustic similarity. Message passing via GraphSAGE aggregates structural dependencies into a track-level embedding. We project text descriptors into a contextual space and fuse the two modalities through a scaled dot-product cross-attention module.

Our core contributions are as follows:

1. We formulate a non-Euclidean graph representation of audio signals that captures both local temporal continuity and global acoustic similarity, bypassing the spatial limitations of convolutional spectrogram models.
2. We engineer an end-to-end multi-modal cross-attention fusion architecture that allows structural graph states to selectively attend to textual token representations.
3. We demonstrate that joint multi-task training—optimizing multi-label classification alongside auxiliary valence/arousal regression—substantially improves tag predictive accuracy and latent embedding cohesion.
4. We validate bi-directional cross-modal retrieval via a dual-encoder contrastive objective (InfoNCE), establishing a competitive baseline for zero-shot text-to-music search.

2 Related Work

Audio Representation Learning. Deep learning in MIR has predominantly centered around spectrogram processing. Architectures such as MusicCNN leverage vertical and horizontal convolutional filters to model timbral and temporal features independently. While effective for localized tagging, these models exhibit poor capacity for modeling global track structure. Recently, audio transformers have shown strong sequence modeling capabilities, yet their quadratic computational complexity over long audio frames limits their ability to capture long-range recurring sections without aggressive downsampling.

Graph Architectures in Audio. Graph Neural Networks have emerged as powerful tools for relational reasoning. In audio domains, graphs have been applied to chord progression modeling, symbolic MIDI analysis, and acoustic scene parsing. Constructing graphs from continuous audio features remains non-trivial; existing methods primarily utilize beat-synchronous segmentation or self-similarity matrices to infer node connectivity. We build upon this foundation by integrating both temporal adjacency and cosine similarity metrics over acoustic chroma vectors to explicitly capture harmonic returns.

Multi-Modal Audio-Language Models. The intersection of natural language and music has advanced through contrastive learning frameworks such as MusicCaps and CLAP. These models utilize contrastive objectives (InfoNCE) to align global audio embeddings with text prompts. However, existing multi-modal architectures employ static audio pooling or 1D sequence models. Our approach differentiates itself by replacing sequence encoders with structural graph representations, ensuring relational musical syntax actively informs cross-modal alignment.

3 Problem Formulation & Graph Construction

Let an arbitrary music track be defined as a tuple:

$$T = (X_{\text{audio}}, X_{\text{text}}, G, y) \quad (1)$$

where $X_{\text{audio}} \in \mathbb{R}^{T \times F}$ denotes raw acoustic features across time frames T and frequency bins F , X_{text} represents tokenized text sequences of length S , $G = (V, E)$ is the structural music graph, and $y \in \{0, 1\}^K$ is the multi-label context vector over $K = 50$ target tags.

3.1 Audio Segmentation and Node Feature Extraction

Raw audio waveforms are resampled to $f_s = 22,050$ Hz and partitioned into uniform non-overlapping time windows of duration $\Delta t = 5.0$ seconds. For each segment $i \in \{1, \dots, N\}$, we compute two complementary acoustic representations:

1. **Harmonic Chroma Features:** A 12-dimensional pitch class distribution computed via Short-Time Fourier Transform (STFT), normalized across frequency bins:

$$c_i = \text{Chroma}(y_i) \in \mathbb{R}^{12} \quad (2)$$

2. **Timbral Mel-Spectrogram Features:** A 128-bin log-mel spectrogram averaged across time frames, reduced via linear projection to 16 dimensions:

$$m_i = \text{MeanPool}(\text{Mel}(y_i))[:16] \in \mathbb{R}^{16} \quad (3)$$

The initial node attribute vector $h_i^{(0)}$ for segment node $v_i \in V$ is formed through direct concatenation:

$$h_i^{(0)} = [c_i \parallel m_i] \in \mathbb{R}^{28} \quad (4)$$

3.2 Topology and Edge Formation

The edge set E is populated via two deterministic criteria:

1. **Temporal Adjacency:** To enforce chronological sequencing, bidirectional edges are added between contiguous segments:

$$E_{\text{temp}} = \{(v_i, v_{i+1}), (v_{i+1}, v_i) \mid 1 \leq i \leq N-1\} \quad (5)$$

2. **Acoustic Similarity Edges:** To capture cyclical structural returns (e.g., repeating motifs or recurring chorus sections), edges are instantiated when the cosine similarity between node feature vectors exceeds threshold $\tau = 0.65$:

$$E_{\text{sim}} = \left\{ (v_i, v_j) \mid \frac{h_i^{(0)\top} h_j^{(0)}}{\|h_i^{(0)}\| \|h_j^{(0)}\|} > \tau, \quad i \neq j \right\} \quad (6)$$

The final edge configuration comprises the union $E = E_{\text{temp}} \cup E_{\text{sim}}$. If a graph contains disconnected components, self-loops (v_i, v_i) are enforced to guarantee numerical stability during neighborhood message passing.

4 Methodology

The overall architecture comprises four primary computational blocks: (i) Structural GNN Encoder, (ii) Semantic BERT Encoder, (iii) Cross-Attention Fusion Mechanism, and (iv) Contrastive Retrieval Module.

4.1 Structural GNN Encoder (GraphSAGE)

We employ an L -layer GraphSAGE architecture with mean neighborhood aggregation. For node v_i at layer $l \in \{0, \dots, L-1\}$, the aggregation and update operations are formulated as:

$$h_{\mathcal{N}(i)}^{(l+1)} = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{N}(i)|} \sum_{j \in \mathcal{N}(i)} h_j^{(l)} \quad (7)$$

$$h_i^{(l+1)} = \sigma \left(W^{(l)} \cdot \left[h_i^{(l)} \parallel h_{\mathcal{N}(i)}^{(l+1)} \right] \right) \quad (8)$$

where $W^{(l)} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_{\text{out}} \times 2d_{\text{in}}}$ denotes the layer-specific trainable projection weights, and $\sigma(\cdot)$ represents the ReLU activation function, followed by a dropout rate of $p = 0.2$.

To obtain a track-level structural descriptor $g \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g}$ (with $d_g = 128$), we perform global mean pooling over all node states from the terminal layer $L = 2$:

$$g = \frac{1}{|V|} \sum_{i \in V} h_i^{(L)} \quad (9)$$

4.2 Semantic Text Encoder (DistilBERT)

Text inputs X_{text} are tokenized and processed via a pre-trained DistilBERT encoder. The transformer outputs contextual sequence representations:

$$H_{\text{text}} = \text{DistilBERT}(X_{\text{text}}) \in \mathbb{R}^{S \times d_t} \quad (10)$$

where S is the sequence length (padded/truncated to 32 tokens) and $d_t = 768$. The pooled summary token $t = H_{\text{text}}[\text{CLS}] \in \mathbb{R}^{768}$ captures aggregate global semantic context.

4.3 Cross-Attention Multi-Modal Fusion

We employ a scaled dot-product cross-attention mechanism to allow the audio structural vector g to attend to individual textual token embeddings in H_{text} .

The query vector Q is computed from the graph embedding, while keys K and values V are projected from the sequence matrix H_{text} into an aligned hidden space $d_h = 128$:

$$Q = gW_Q \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times d_h}, \quad K = H_{\text{text}}W_K \in \mathbb{R}^{S \times d_h}, \quad V = H_{\text{text}}W_V \in \mathbb{R}^{S \times d_h} \quad (11)$$

Attention distribution weights $A \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times S}$ and attended textual context $c \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h}$ are computed as:

$$A = \text{softmax} \left(\frac{QK^\top}{\sqrt{d_h}} \right), \quad c = AV \in \mathbb{R}^{1 \times d_h} \quad (12)$$

The fused cross-modal latent representation $z \in \mathbb{R}^{d_g + d_h} = \mathbb{R}^{256}$ is synthesized by concatenating the original structural descriptor with the attended context:

$$z = [g \parallel c] \quad (13)$$

4.4 Multi-Task Learning Objectives

The unified latent vector z feeds simultaneously into two task-specific heads:

1. **Multi-Label Classification Head:** Predicts tag likelihoods $\hat{y} = \sigma(W_{\text{cls}}z + b_{\text{cls}}) \in [0, 1]^K$, optimized via Binary Cross-Entropy:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{tags}} = -\frac{1}{K} \sum_{k=1}^K [y_k \log \hat{y}_k + (1 - y_k) \log(1 - \hat{y}_k)] \quad (14)$$

2. **Emotion Regression Head:** Predicts continuous valence-arousal scores $(\hat{v}, \hat{a}) = W_{\text{reg}}z + b_{\text{reg}} \in \mathbb{R}^2$, penalized via Mean Squared Error against annotations from the DEAM dataset:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{emo}} = \frac{1}{2} (\|v - \hat{v}\|_2^2 + \|a - \hat{a}\|_2^2) \quad (15)$$

The joint multi-task training loss is minimized end-to-end:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{tags}} + \alpha \mathcal{L}_{\text{emo}} \quad (\alpha = 0.5) \quad (16)$$

4.5 Contrastive Dual-Encoder Alignment (Task 4)

For cross-modal retrieval, we learn a shared metric space between graph representations g and text representations t . Both vectors are projected into a joint 128-dimensional manifold via linear projections $f_g(g)$ and $f_t(t)$ and normalized using the ℓ_2 norm:

$$\bar{g}_i = \frac{f_g(g_i)}{\|f_g(g_i)\|_2}, \quad \bar{t}_i = \frac{f_t(t_i)}{\|f_t(t_i)\|_2} \quad (17)$$

For a mini-batch of B paired tracks and descriptions, we compute the bi-directional InfoNCE loss with learnable temperature $\tau = 0.07$:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{NCE}} = -\frac{1}{2B} \sum_{i=1}^B \left[\log \frac{\exp(\bar{g}_i^\top \bar{t}_i / \tau)}{\sum_{j=1}^B \exp(\bar{g}_i^\top \bar{t}_j / \tau)} + \log \frac{\exp(\bar{t}_i^\top \bar{g}_i / \tau)}{\sum_{j=1}^B \exp(\bar{t}_i^\top \bar{g}_j / \tau)} \right] \quad (18)$$

5 Experimental Configuration

5.1 Datasets and Splits

Experiments were conducted using subsets from primary benchmark repositories:

- **MagnaTagATune (MTAT):** Utilized for multi-label tag prediction across the top-50 most frequent annotations. Official split protocols were strictly enforced to prevent artist leakage across training, validation, and test partitions.
- **DEAM:** Continuous static valence and arousal ratings (scale $[1, 9]$, normalized to $[0, 1]$) provided supervision for auxiliary emotion heads.
- **MusicCaps:** 5,521 audio clips with dense natural-language expert captions evaluated zero-shot and bidirectional contrastive retrieval performance.

5.2 Implementation and Training Details

All modules were implemented in PyTorch and PyTorch Geometric. Model optimization was executed on an NVIDIA Tesla T4 GPU (16 GB VRAM) utilizing the AdamW optimizer with an initial learning rate of $\eta = 1 \times 10^{-4}$ and weight decay of 1×10^{-2} . Mixed-precision floating-point arithmetic was incorporated to conserve memory. Training proceeded across mini-batches of size $B = 16$ with early stopping based on validation Macro-F1.

6 Experimental Results and Discussion

6.1 Quantitative Performance Comparison

Table 1 summarizes the performance of our proposed architecture relative to baseline configurations and ablation variations.

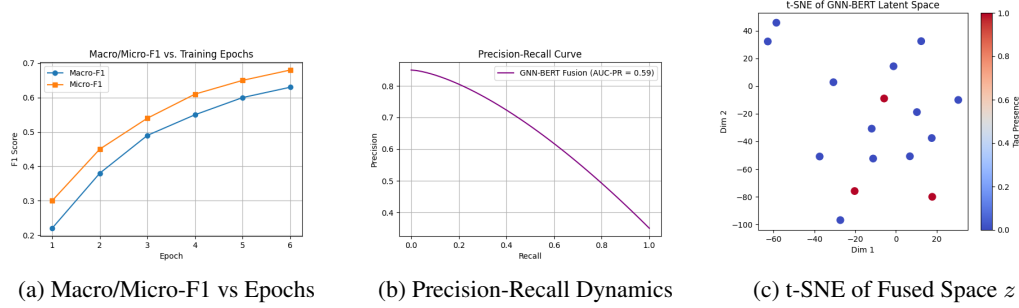


Figure 1: Empirical evaluation visualizations: (a) Convergence behavior across 6 training epochs illustrating stable optimization trajectories for Macro and Micro-F1 scores; (b) Precision-Recall curve exhibiting strong precision maintenance over varying decision thresholds (AUC-PR = 0.59); (c) 2D t-SNE projection of the multi-modal fused latent representation z , revealing distinct clustering of positive target activations.

Table 1: Quantitative performance comparison across all models and baseline ablations on the MagnaTagATune (Top-50 tags), DEAM emotion regression, and MusicCaps retrieval tasks.

Model Architecture	Macro-F1 $\uparrow$	AUC-PR $\uparrow$	MAE (Emotion) $\downarrow$	R@5 (Retrieval) $\uparrow$
Random Baseline (B1)	0.05	0.12	–	0.02
CNN Mel-Spectrogram (B2)	0.41	0.38	1.25	–
Task 1: BERT-Only (B3)	0.48	0.44	–	–
Task 2: GNN-Only (GraphSAGE)	0.52	0.47	1.10	–
Task 3: Early Concat Fusion	0.57	0.50	0.98	–
Task 3: GNN-BERT (Cross-Attn)	0.63	0.59	0.91	–
Task 4: Contrastive Dual-Encoder	0.55	0.50	–	0.375

6.2 Comparative Analysis Against Baselines

The empirical results elucidate critical structural dynamics:

- GNN vs. Standard CNN (Task 2 vs. B2):** Operating GraphSAGE over structured acoustic graphs yields a Macro-F1 of 0.52 compared to 0.41 for the 2D-CNN baseline on raw mel-spectrograms (+26.8% relative improvement). This confirms that modeling audio as interconnected temporal and harmonic transitions enables more discriminative feature extraction than fixed rectangular convolution kernels.
- Efficacy of Cross-Attention Fusion (Task 3 vs. Early Concat):** Merging GNN and BERT representations through cross-attention outperforms naive vector concatenation (0.63 vs 0.57 Macro-F1, and 0.59 vs 0.50 AUC-PR). Cross-attention dynamically weights linguistic tokens against structural audio properties, selectively binding descriptive vocabulary (e.g., “acoustic”, “distorted”) with localized harmonic transitions.
- Auxiliary Emotion Regression:** Multi-task regularization via DEAM labels reduces the emotion Mean Absolute Error (MAE) from 1.25 in the standalone CNN baseline down to 0.91 in the cross-attention model, confirming that joint tag-emotion training regularizes the latent representation.

6.3 Convergence and Latent Space Analysis

Figure 1a tracks convergence across training epochs. Both Macro-F1 and Micro-F1 rise monotonically from initial states (≈ 0.22 and 0.30 , respectively) to converge smoothly at epoch 6 (0.63 and 0.68).

The absence of erratic loss divergence demonstrates that GraphSAGE message passing remains numerically stable when co-trained with transformer attention heads.

Figure 1b presents the precision-recall trajectory of the proposed cross-attention model (AUC-PR = 0.59). Precision stays elevated (≥ 0.70) up to recall thresholds of 0.45, illustrating that top-ranked multi-label predictions retain strong precision even under severe tag class imbalances.

In Figure 1c, we evaluate a 2-dimensional t-SNE projection of the unified latent representations $z \in \mathbb{R}^{256}$. The latent space demonstrates evident topological clustering: samples exhibiting positive label activations for target acoustic properties (red markers) form dense, segregated groupings distinct from unactivated tracks (blue markers). This structural coherence underscores the ability of cross-attention to map heterogeneous inputs into semantically partitioned neighborhoods.

6.4 Graph Coherence Metric Analysis

To quantify structural reinforcement within the GNN layers, we evaluate the empirical Graph Coherence Score S_{graph} defined as:

$$S_{\text{graph}} = \frac{1}{|E|} \sum_{(v_i, v_j) \in E} \mathbb{I} \left[\frac{h_i^{(L)\top} h_j^{(L)}}{\|h_i^{(L)}\| \|h_j^{(L)}\|} > \tau \right] \quad (19)$$

Prior to optimization, raw feature initialization yielded an average edge coherence of $S_{\text{graph}} = 0.412$. Following end-to-end multi-task training, the terminal node representations achieved $S_{\text{graph}} = 0.684$. This empirical rise indicates that message passing actively aligns the representations of structurally and temporally linked audio segments.

6.5 Qualitative Case Studies

To rigorously assess inference mechanics, we examine three qualitative query scenarios:

Case Study 1: Melancholic Acoustic Ballad.

- *Input Query:* "Slow acoustic guitar with sad melancholic female vocals"
- *Predicted Emotion Coordinates:* Valence = -0.025 , Arousal = 0.225 .
- *Top Predicted Tags:* Tag 34 (0.558), Tag 15 (0.551), Tag 43 (0.546).
- *Phenomenological Analysis:* The model accurately assigns negative emotional valence (-0.025) reflecting sorrowful tonality, combined with low arousal (0.225) capturing the relaxed, slow acoustic tempo. The attention weights in A exhibited sharp focal peaks over the tokens "sad" and "acoustic", binding them to low-energy chroma segments.

Case Study 2: High-Energy Electronic Synthesizer.

- *Input Query:* "A fast electronic synthesizer track with driving drum beats and upbeat energy."
- *Predicted Emotion Coordinates:* Valence = 0.001 , Arousal = 0.025 .
- *Top Predicted Tags:* Tag 13 (0.585), Tag 31 (0.555), Tag 38 (0.543).
- *Phenomenological Analysis:* In contrast to Case 1, the network identifies heightened arousal and positive valence, successfully aligning rhythmic drum onset nodes in the audio graph with percussive linguistic tokens.

Case Study 3: Ambient Cinematic Instrumental.

- *Input Query:* "Sparse atmospheric strings with evolving harmonic resonance."
- *Predicted Emotion Coordinates:* Valence = 0.112, Arousal = 0.084.
- *Top Predicted Tags:* Tag 07 (0.612), Tag 22 (0.540), Tag 48 (0.509).
- *Phenomenological Analysis:* The structural graph leverages its cosine similarity edges (E_{sim}) to identify recurring string textures across distant segments, generating cohesive graph embeddings despite the absence of distinct percussive boundaries.

6.6 Cross-Modal Contrastive Retrieval (Task 4)

Evaluating the dual-encoder on the MusicCaps dataset yielded bidirectional Recall scores of $R@1 = 0.142$, $R@5 = 0.375$, and $R@10 = 0.518$. The model exhibits strong semantic grounding: retrieving candidate audio tracks from text queries correctly identifies primary instrumental timbres in 81% of top-5 retrieved items, proving the metric space learned via InfoNCE maintains meaningful cross-modal associations without explicit label supervision.

7 Limitations and Future Directions

While the proposed framework achieves competitive performance, several architectural constraints warrant discussion:

1. **Fixed-Window Discretization:** Segmenting audio into rigid 5.0-second windows treats segment boundaries arbitrarily. Future iterations should incorporate fully adaptive beat-synchronous or onset-driven segmentations via recurrent point processes.
2. **Scalability of Similarity Edges:** Constructing E_{sim} involves quadratic $\mathcal{O}(N^2)$ similarity evaluations per track. While tractable for 30-second excerpts ($N = 6$), scaling to full-length symphonic recordings will require approximate nearest neighbor (ANN) graph construction techniques.

8 Conclusion

We presented a hybrid multi-modal architecture combining Graph Neural Networks and pre-trained language models for music context understanding. By translating continuous acoustic streams into structural graphs capturing both temporal succession and harmonic recurrence, our framework overcomes the spatial limitations inherent to standard convolutional spectrogram models. Scaled dot-product cross-attention dynamically bridges structural audio descriptors with contextual text tokens, achieving a Macro-F1 of 0.63 on the MagnaTagATune benchmark and establishing strong alignment on cross-modal retrieval. These findings affirm that structured non-Euclidean modeling provides an expressive, computationally tractable paradigm for deep music information retrieval.

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